WiseIQ

Smart Money Tools

Credit Score Boost
Cheat Sheet

The 7 highest-impact actions to raise your score — ranked by speed

Quick Reference | Actionable Steps | Score Science Explained

How to Use This Cheat Sheet

Your credit score is calculated by a specific formula. Once you understand exactly what moves the needle — and by how much — you can stop guessing and start making targeted moves that produce results within weeks, not years.

This cheat sheet ranks the 7 highest-impact actions by two criteria: **score impact** (how many points you can realistically expect) and **time to reflect** (how long before the change shows up on your report). Work through them in order — the top actions give you the fastest gains.

What Your Score Is Actually Made Of

FICO scores — used in 90% of lending decisions — are calculated from five factors. Most people focus on the wrong ones. Here is the exact breakdown:

Factor	Weight	What It Measures	Fastest Way to Improve
Payment History	35%	Whether you pay on time. One 30-day late can drop your score 60–110 points.	Never miss another payment. Set autopay for minimums immediately.
Credit Utilization	30%	How much of your available revolving credit you are using across all cards.	Pay balances down before statement closing date, not due date.
Length of Credit History	15%	Average age of all accounts, age of oldest account, age of newest account.	Never close old cards. Even unused cards help your average age.
Credit Mix	10%	Having both revolving (cards) and installment (loans) accounts.	A credit-builder loan adds installment history if you only have cards.
New Credit	10%	Hard inquiries from recent applications. Each inquiry costs 5–10 points.	Space applications 6+ months apart. Rate shopping within 14 days counts as one inquiry.

The Most Misunderstood Rule in Credit Scoring

Most people think paying your bill by the due date is what matters for utilization. It is not. Your utilization is calculated from your **statement balance** — the balance on the day your statement closes, which is typically 21 days before your due date. If you carry a $900 balance on a $1,000 card all month and pay it off on the due date, your report still shows 90% utilization. Pay before the statement closes.

What the Score Ranges Actually Mean

Score Range	Rating	What Lenders See	Typical APR Impact
800–850	Exceptional	Best rates, instant approvals, highest limits	Lowest available rates

Score Range	Rating	What Lenders See	Typical APR Impact
740–799	Very Good	Strong approvals, near-best rates	+0.5–1.5% vs. exceptional
670–739	Good	Most products available, standard rates	+1.5–3% vs. exceptional
580–669	Fair	Limited options, higher rates, lower limits	+4–8% vs. exceptional
300–579	Poor	Mostly secured cards and credit-builder products only	+8–15%+ vs. exceptional

The Real Cost of a Fair vs. Good Score

On a $25,000 auto loan over 60 months: a "Good" score (700) might get you 6.5% APR — a "Fair" score (620) might get you 12.5% APR. That difference costs you **$4,200 more** over the life of the loan. On a $300,000 mortgage, the same gap costs over **$60,000**. Every point you add has a real dollar value.

THE 7 HIGHEST-IMPACT ACTIONS — RANKED BY SPEED & POINTS

#1 Reduce Credit Utilization Below 10%

Score Impact: +20 to +80 points (most people see 30–50)

Time to Reflect: 1 billing cycle (21–35 days)

How it works: Utilization is calculated both per-card and overall. FICO penalizes you at 30%, heavily at 50%, and severely at 70%+. The target is under 10% on every individual card AND under 10% overall. A card with a $5,000 limit should show no more than $500 on the statement. If you cannot pay it down, call and request a credit limit increase — this instantly lowers your utilization ratio without paying a dollar.

Pro Tip: The 30-10-1 Rule: Keep overall utilization under 30%, per-card under 10%, and ideally report exactly $1 on at least one card (not $0 — a $0 balance means the card is not being used, which scores slightly lower than $1).

#2 Dispute All Inaccurate Negative Items

Score Impact: +25 to +100+ points per item removed

Time to Reflect: 30–45 days per dispute cycle

How it works: Under the FCRA, any item on your report that is inaccurate, unverifiable, or incomplete must be removed. Bureaus have 30 days to investigate. Studies show 1 in 5 Americans has an error on their credit report. Common errors: wrong balance, wrong status (shows open when paid), duplicate accounts, accounts that are not yours, and late payments reported incorrectly. Each removed negative item can add significant points depending on its severity and age.

Pro Tip: Dispute with all three bureaus separately — Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion each maintain independent databases. An item removed from one bureau does not automatically come off the others. Use certified mail with return receipt for paper disputes — this creates a legal paper trail.

ACTIONS 3–4 | CONTINUED

#3 Become an Authorized User on a Strong Account

Score Impact: +10 to +50 points

Time to Reflect: 1–2 billing cycles (30–60 days)

How it works: When someone adds you as an authorized user on their credit card, that account's entire history — including its age, payment history, and utilization — appears on your credit report. You do not need to use the card or even have it in your possession. The primary cardholder's good behavior becomes your good behavior on paper. Best accounts to be added to: old cards (10+ years), low utilization (<10%), and perfect payment history.

Pro Tip: This works even with a stranger through "tradeline rental" services, but the impact is less reliable and the practice is frowned upon by lenders. A family member or close friend with excellent credit is the most effective and legitimate route.

#4 Pay Every Account On Time — Without Exception

Score Impact: +0 to +20 points (prevents catastrophic drops)

Time to Reflect: Immediate — but recovery from a late takes 12–24 months

How it works: Payment history is 35% of your score. A single 30-day late payment can drop your score 60–110 points depending on your starting score (higher scores fall harder). A 90-day late is worse. A charge-off or collection is devastating. The most important thing you can do is set autopay for the minimum on every account so you never miss a payment due to forgetfulness. You can always pay more manually — autopay is your safety net.

Pro Tip: If you have a late payment from the last 2 years, call the creditor and ask for a "goodwill adjustment." Many creditors will remove a single late payment if you have an otherwise clean history and have been a customer in good standing. This is not guaranteed but works more often than people expect.

ACTIONS 5–7 | CONTINUED

#5 Request Credit Limit Increases on Existing Cards

Score Impact: +10 to +40 points

Time to Reflect: 1 billing cycle after increase posts

How it works: A credit limit increase lowers your utilization ratio instantly without paying down any debt. Example: $3,000 balance on a $5,000 limit = 60% utilization. After a limit increase to $10,000: same $3,000 balance = 30% utilization. Most issuers allow a limit increase request every 6–12 months. Call the number on the back of your card and ask. Many issuers do a soft pull (no score impact) for existing customers. Ask specifically: "Will this require a hard inquiry?"

Pro Tip: The best time to request a limit increase is after a raise, after 6+ months of on-time payments, or after your income has increased. Have your current income ready — issuers will ask. Chase, Citi, and Capital One all allow online requests that often result in instant decisions with only a soft pull.

#6 Add a Credit-Builder Loan or Secured Card

Score Impact: +10 to +35 points (especially for thin files)

Time to Reflect: 3–6 months for meaningful impact

How it works: If you have fewer than 3 open accounts or no installment loan history, adding a credit-builder loan improves your credit mix (10% of score) and adds positive payment history. Credit-builder loans work in reverse: the lender holds the money in a savings account while you make monthly payments. At the end, you get the money back. Self Financial and Credit Strong are the most popular options ($25–$35/month). A secured credit card (you deposit collateral) works similarly for revolving history.

Pro Tip: Discover it Secured and Capital One Platinum Secured both graduate to unsecured cards after 6–8 months of on-time payments — and your deposit is returned. This is the fastest legitimate path from no credit to a 680+ score.

#7 Never Close Old Credit Card Accounts

Score Impact: Prevents -10 to -50 point drops

Time to Reflect: Immediate (closing an account hurts instantly)

How it works: Closing a credit card does two things that hurt your score: (1) it reduces your total available credit, which raises your utilization ratio, and (2) it eventually removes the account's age from your average account age calculation. A card you have had for 10 years is a significant asset to your credit history. Even if you do not use it, keep it open. If there is an annual fee, call and ask to downgrade to a no-fee version of the same card — most issuers will do this.

Pro Tip: To keep an old card active without using it, set one small recurring charge (like a $5/month streaming service) and autopay the full balance. This keeps the account open, maintains a perfect payment history, and keeps utilization near zero.

QUICK REFERENCE: WHAT HURTS VS. WHAT HELPS

Action	Score Impact	Notes
Missing a payment (30+ days late)	–60 to –110 pts	Stays on report 7 years. Goodwill removal possible.
Maxing out a credit card (90%+ utilization)	–30 to –75 pts	Recovers within 1 billing cycle once paid down.
Applying for 3+ cards in 6 months	–15 to –30 pts	Each hard inquiry = –5 to –10 pts. Fades after 12 months.
Closing an old credit card	–10 to –50 pts	Depends on age of card and how much available credit is lost.
A collection account appearing	–50 to –110 pts	Paid collections still show. Negotiate pay-for-delete.
Paying down utilization to <10%	+20 to +80 pts	Fastest single action. Reflects in 1 billing cycle.
Removing one inaccurate negative item	+25 to +100 pts	Depends on severity. Collections and charge-offs have most impact.
Requesting a credit limit increase	+10 to +40 pts	Instant utilization improvement. Ask for soft pull only.
Adding authorized user status	+10 to +50 pts	Depends on age and quality of the primary account.
6 months of on-time payments	+15 to +40 pts	Cumulative effect. Consistency matters more than any single payment.

30 / 60 / 90 DAY SCORE IMPROVEMENT TIMELINE

Timeframe	Actions to Take	Expected Result
Days 1–7	Pull all 3 reports at AnnualCreditReport.com. Identify every negative item. Set autopay on all accounts. Pay down highest-utilization card first.	No score change yet — you are setting the foundation.
Days 8–21	Send dispute letters to all three bureaus for inaccurate items. Call each credit card issuer and request a credit limit increase. Pay remaining cards down to under 10% utilization before statement close.	Utilization improvement posts within 1 billing cycle.
Days 22–35	First billing cycle closes. New utilization reflects on report. Monitor score — expect +20 to +60 points if utilization was high. Follow up on any disputes that have not received a response.	+20 to +60 points from utilization reduction.

Timeframe	Actions to Take	Expected Result
Days 36–60	Dispute responses arrive. Items verified, updated, or removed. Continue on-time payments. If no dispute response in 30 days, send follow-up and file CFPB complaint if needed.	+25 to +100 pts per item removed from disputes.
Days 61–90	Second billing cycle closes. Maintain <10% utilization. If score is above 640, consider applying for a secured card or credit-builder loan to diversify credit mix.	Cumulative gains: +40 to +150 points total is realistic for most people.
Days 91–120	Review all dispute outcomes. For any item still showing incorrectly, escalate to the CFPB at consumerfinance.gov/complaint. File a complaint naming the bureau and the furnisher. Bureaus respond to CFPB complaints within 15 days — much faster than standard disputes.	Additional removals possible. CFPB escalation resolves ~60% of previously denied disputes.
Days 121–180	If score is now above 640–660, apply for one new credit card (preferably a card with no annual fee and a credit limit increase path). A new account adds to credit mix and increases total available credit. Do not apply for more than one card in this window.	Credit mix improvement. New positive history begins building. Score may dip 5–10 pts temporarily from hard inquiry, then recover.

HOW TO MONITOR YOUR SCORE — FOR FREE

You do not need to pay for credit monitoring. Every tool below is free and gives you real-time access to your score and report data:

Tool	Score Model	Bureau	Update Frequency	Best For
Credit Karma	VantageScore 3.0	TransUnion + Equifax	Weekly	Free monitoring + dispute alerts
Experian Free	FICO Score 8	Experian	Monthly	Most lender-used score model
Chase Credit Journey	VantageScore 3.0	TransUnion	Weekly	Chase customers — no card required
Capital One CreditWise	VantageScore 3.0	TransUnion	Weekly	Anyone — no Capital One account needed
Discover ScoreCard	FICO Score 8	TransUnion	Monthly	Free FICO score — no Discover card needed
AnnualCreditReport.com	Full report (no score)	All 3 bureaus	Weekly (since 2020)	Full report review — pull all 3 at once

FICO vs. VantageScore: Which One Matters?

FICO Score 8 is used in 90% of lending decisions — mortgages, auto loans, and most credit cards. **VantageScore** (used by Credit Karma) is a competing model that tends to score people slightly higher. The two scores often differ by 20–40 points. Always check your FICO score before applying for a major loan — use Experian free or Discover ScoreCard for the most accurate pre-application picture.

COMMON MYTHS — DEBUNKED

The Myth	The Truth
"Checking my own score hurts it."	False. Checking your own score is a soft inquiry and has zero impact. Only hard inquiries (from lenders when you apply for credit) affect your score.
"Carrying a small balance helps your score."	False. This myth costs people money in interest. Paying in full every month is better than carrying a balance. What helps is having the card report a small balance (pay before statement close, not before due date).
"Closing a paid-off card improves your score."	False. Closing a card removes available credit and can reduce your average account age. Keep old cards open, even if unused.
"Paying a collection removes it from your report."	False — unless you negotiate a pay-for-delete agreement in writing first. Paid collections still show as "paid collection" for 7 years. Always negotiate removal before paying.
"You need to hire a credit repair company."	False. Anything a credit repair company can legally do, you can do yourself for free. They cannot remove accurate negative information. The FCRA gives you all the same rights.

Your Next Step

Start with Action #1 today: go to AnnualCreditReport.com, pull all three reports, and identify your highest-utilization card. Pay it down before your next statement closing date. That single action is the fastest point gain available to most people. Then work through the remaining 6 actions in order over the next 90 days.

FREE OFFICIAL RESOURCES

Resource	What It Does	URL
AnnualCreditReport.com	Pull all 3 free credit reports weekly. The only federally mandated free source.	annualcreditreport.com
CFPB Complaint Portal	File complaints against bureaus or creditors. Gets results in 15 days.	consumerfinance.gov/complaint
CFPB Credit Report Guide	Official guide to understanding and disputing your credit report.	consumerfinance.gov/consumer-tools/credit-reports-and-scores

Resource	What It Does	URL
FTC Identity Theft Center	Free identity theft recovery plan and dispute letters.	identitytheft.gov
NCUA Credit Union Locator	Find a credit union near you — credit unions often approve secured cards more easily.	mycreditunion.gov

Disclaimer

This cheat sheet is for educational purposes only and does not constitute legal or financial advice. Credit score impacts vary by individual.